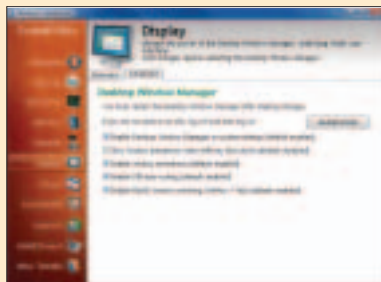


Invisible shortcuts

A rather frustrating feature of Vista is that if you create a shortcut icon for an application, that icon is then blighted by an unsightly curved arrow in the bottom-left corner. Although by no means detrimental, it can ruin an attractive-looking Desktop. To remove these arrows from shortcut icons, all you need to do is download a free application called Vista Shortcut Manager from www.frameworkx.com. This simple tool is easy to use and, if you'd rather not remove the arrow completely, has an alternative option to make the arrows less obtrusive.

Tweaking software

If you fancy taking your Vista customisation further, there are plenty of applications to give you a helping hand. One of the most popular is Stardock Tweakvita, which offers the option of one-click enhancements along with more advanced options. Download a free trial version of the software from www.stardock.com.



Tweakvita is just one of many third-party tweaking applications that helps you to customise Windows

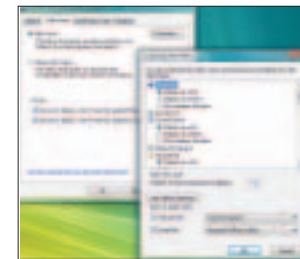
Tweakvi provides similar functionality to Tweakvita, but the Basic Edition is free so it's well worth checking out. There's plenty for beginners and advanced users, spanning everything from changing the look of Vista to enhancing performance. Download Tweakvi from www.totalidea.com/product.php.

Windowblinds is another well-established application that lets you customise Vista. Using its skinning tools, you can completely change the look of Vista's interface in one go. Download a free trial version from www.stardock.com.

There are many more Vista customisation applications on the cover CD, as well as a complete guide to using one of them – namely Tuneup Utilities 2007.

Ultimate extras

Those running the Ultimate version of Vista also have access to a range of free add-on applications. To find out what add-ons are available for download, click on the Start button, type 'Extras' and press Enter. You'll now be directed to the Windows Update site where you'll be told if there are new Extras available for download. If there are, click on the View Available Extras link to read more about the individual applications and then select those you want to install.



It's easy to change how Vista's Taskbar operates

The next steps

As we've demonstrated, if you don't like a certain aspect of Vista there's a good chance you'll be able to change it to suit your needs. And with an almost endless range of customisable features available, it's well worth getting hold of some software to help you tweak your copy of the operating system. You'll not only add your own personal touch to Vista, but also enhance its performance.



Create your own customised searches within Vista

Over the next few pages, we'll take you through some of the most popular customisation tweaks, so read on to find out how to make your version of Vista truly unique.